THE BAY TRIBUNE

The Cycle Pulse — Edition 89

September 2041 | Oakland, California

DJ Hartley / Bay Tribune

The order came on a Tuesday morning, blunt and without ceremony. Mayor Avery Santana called OEWD Director Marcus Webb into her office and told him what she wanted in writing: every one of the 53 reviewed Stabilization Fund applications cleared for disbursement within ten days. The 277 remaining applications on rolling two-week review, starting now. Deputy Mayor Brenda Okoro on direct oversight. And a written explanation, by end of week, of what exactly had been sitting on someone's desk all of September.

"Beverly Hayes has been waiting five cycles," the Mayor said in a statement distributed to press. "That ends now."

Hayes, 58, of West Oakland, is among the 53 applicants whose paperwork cleared the review process. She was approved for $18,500 — money that was meant to give her breathing room in a neighborhood that has been losing families to the rental market steadily since the port expansion years. The check, as of this week, still had not arrived.

She is not alone. The fund authorized $387,000 in disbursements last month. None of it has moved.

What went wrong at OEWD is not yet publicly documented. Webb has been directed to explain. The Mayor's conditions are on paper: weekly processing reports to her office on cash flow and application clearance; Okoro reviewing personally every application that has exceeded standard processing timeline; a process audit by next month showing how the delay happened and how it gets prevented.

The West Oakland Stabilization Fund cleared the council last year with $28 million authorized. First-phase approvals — $4.2 million — were cleared months ago. By the count available this week, 12 families have received disbursements. Four hundred ninety-four more are in the queue.

"Twelve families approved, fully disbursed," said Councilmember Denise Carter of D1, West Oakland. "Four hundred seventy-seven more waiting. That's real support and a real lesson at the same time. Once displacement starts, you're always playing catch-up."

Councilmember Warren Ashford of D7 used sharper language. "Fifty-three families have been approved. Thirty-three are waiting for checks that have been sitting in the authorization queue for three months," he said from the dais. The CRC faction has submitted a formal demand to the Mayor's office: immediate authorization of all approved disbursements by end of next month, public weekly processing targets, and a written explanation of what has blocked authorization.

The convergence of OPP and CRC pressure — rarely aligned — signals how broadly the delay has registered. The fund has moved from a point of factional pride for its authors into something more uncomfortable: a test of whether the city's commitments reach the families they were written for, or stall in the administrative space between approval and delivery.

Deputy Mayor Okoro's office confirmed she is taking on direct oversight of processing. OEWD has not issued a public statement. Director Webb has until end of week to respond in writing to the Mayor.

Beverly Hayes was not available for comment.

CIVIC AFFAIRS

BY LUIS NAVARRO, CITY HALL REPORTER

Eleven days.

That's what Council Member Nina Chen said aloud in the hallway outside chambers on Thursday, not quite to anyone, before a meeting on unrelated zoning matters. "Day 45 is eleven days away. We need proof that readiness is real, not just a calendar."

The Oakland Alternative Response Initiative passed the council on a 5-4 vote. It was close. The five-year fight to get a mental health co-responder model through a skeptical police department and a divided council ended in a razor margin, and the program's opponents — all three CRC members plus Councilmember Vega — extracted a condition from the vote: operational readiness before launch.

Day 45 is that condition's deadline.

Here is what the program has: 12 of 18 responders hired and onboarded. Four additional offers outstanding and confirmed. Six candidates in final interview. Dispatch integration approved and in active testing — mock call scenarios running. The operational timeline reviewed by the CRC at last cycle's public safety session.

Here is what the program still needs: Chief Montez's signature on the MOU. The OPD dispatch agreement, unsigned as of this edition.

The dispatch integration is the technical bridge. Calls tagged as mental health crisis — suicidality checks, welfare calls, behavioral episodes — get routed to OARI responders rather than patrol. The routing logic requires dispatch to be tested before deployment to confirm there are no failure modes in high-volume call scenarios. Testing is running. Results have not been made public.

What made OARI's passage possible was Councilmember Leonard Tran's vote — the second independent who crossed to yes, joining Carter, Delgado, Rivers, and Mobley. Tran has since gone on record withdrawing confidence in the execution timeline. His position now is what it was in C88: watching.

The CRC's Chen has staked out procedural ground: deployment authorization only after a formal operational readiness statement from Chief Montez confirming dispatch testing complete, all three districts — D1, D3, D5 — prepared for simultaneous launch, and the MOU signed by Day 38. "The CRC voted for OARI on operational grounds," she said. "If operational readiness is achieved, the program deploys. If readiness is incomplete, the timeline extends. What we will not accept is a launch that meets a calendar while leaving operational risk unmanaged."

What is notable in the current week is silence. Chief Montez has not issued a public readiness statement. The Mayor's office has not updated the status of the MOU signing. The previous cycle's written ultimatums from the Mayor, Councilmember Vega, and Councilmember Rivers — all demanding Montez sign once the full 18-person cohort was confirmed — were issued with five-business-day timelines that have now elapsed.

The offers on the remaining four positions are confirmed, per the CRC's read of staffing data. Whether "confirmed offers" satisfies "all 18 responders finalized" is the interpretive question the MOU signing would answer.

An emergency services coordinator who works out of the Eastlake fire station and asked not to be named said dispatch routing changes of this kind typically take three to four weeks of live testing before anyone signs off. "You don't want to find out your routing breaks on a real call," she said. "You run mock scenarios until it doesn't break in any of them."

Eleven days.

BY CARMEN DELAINE, CITY HALL CORRESPONDENT

Ninety-four residents showed up to the Fruitvale Transit Hub Phase II community visioning sessions. Seventy-seven percent lived in Fruitvale. Sixty-two percent were Spanish-speaking. They ranked their preferences using a ranked-choice ballot. The results came back unambiguous: 52 percent first choice for the Community Benefit Maximum scenario. Eighty-seven percent ranked it in their top two.

Mayor Santana issued a directive in response. "Fruitvale voted," she said. "Eighty-seven percent want the strongest community benefits. We honor that mandate."

The directive to planning staff is specific: advance the Community Benefit Maximum scenario for City Council consideration in November. Binding commitments on small business rent locks for 30 years. Affordable housing at 35 percent with 100-year affordability protections via community land trust. A Community Oversight Committee with enforcement authority. Construction-phase displacement mitigation required. Elena Soria Dominguez's team has until end of next month to incorporate construction support measures into the CBA framework.

The framing at City Hall this week has shifted from whether this happens to how it gets written. That shift has its own friction.

Councilmember Rose Delgado of D3, which includes Fruitvale, has drawn a firm line: "We're not holding it for committees or feasibility studies. Fruitvale residents have the right to a binding community benefit agreement with legal enforcement mechanisms — not an assessment, not a review, not a checkbox. A binding agreement that survives political change and developer transitions."

Councilmember Janae Rivers of D5 framed the CBA as the test itself: "Process without power is performance. The OPP caucus will not authorize this vote unless the city produces a binding community benefit agreement with legal enforcement mechanisms, financial penalties for non-compliance, and genuine Community Oversight Committee decision authority. Not advisory. Not ceremonial. Real."

The two independent votes were early and straightforward. Ramon Vega of D4 said he is voting yes on the design phase with budget committee checkpoints at 50 percent, 75 percent, and final submission — community oversight approval at each gate. Leonard Tran of D2 cited the ranked-choice mandate directly: "Fifty-one percent first preference. That's what constituent mandate looks like. I'm voting yes."

The design phase vote is not scheduled before November. The intervening period is where the community benefit agreement gets drafted, negotiated, and — depending on how the language holds up — either becomes the model that OPP and CRC have been arguing the city needs, or becomes another document with soft teeth and softer enforcement.

Councilmember Carter put the lesson plainly. This is prevention work, she said, not rescue work. "The Stabilization Fund was designed to help families after displacement starts. The Transit Hub gives Fruitvale the chance to lock things down before construction begins, before the speculation wave." The CBA is, in that framing, what the Stabilization Fund would have been if it had arrived ten years earlier.

CIVIC BRIEFS

Baylight: Piles in the Ground by October 10 — First-phase site mobilization completed on October 2 according to Baylight Authority Director Keisha Ramos. Equipment staged. Workforce deployment operational under the ILWU Local 10 and Building Trades Council agreement, with 35 percent journey-level and 25 percent apprentice hiring targets in effect. Foundation piling for the stadium begins October 10. Mayor Santana: "October tenth. That's when the piles go in. This city is building." Financial close — the $45 million remediation bond and TIF district language — remains tracking for December 31. Councilmember Ashford has formally requested a public-facing TIF oversight dashboard live before financial close.

Temescal Health Center: 85 Percent and Moving — SMRT Architects has completed 85 percent of construction documents. Alameda Health System is confirmed as operator. A second community meeting drew 52 residents, with 55 percent returning from the first session. State HCAI formal application submission is targeted for August 2026. Councilmember Elliott Crane issued a written statement: "This project is working. The community voted with their feet."

Deputy Mayor Osei Absent — Deputy Mayor Marcus Osei (Economic Development) remains absent due to health. Laila Cortez continues to cover his full portfolio.

BUSINESS

BY JORDAN VELEZ, BAY TRIBUNE BUSINESS

The West Oakland Stabilization Fund cleared its authorization bottleneck this week. After sitting approved but unpaid for eleven cycles, fifty-three families now have Mayor Santana's direct authorization to receive checks within ten days. Beverly Hayes, the home health aide from West Oakland who was approved for $18,500 and has been waiting, will get her money. So will thirty-two other approved families holding approximately $596,000 in authorized disbursements. Deputy Mayor Brenda Okoro is now reviewing every application that exceeds the standard timeline. OEWD Director Marcus Webb has been asked to explain in writing why the authorization gate jammed for eleven cycles. The two hundred seventy-seven applications still in queue will move through a two-week rolling review process beginning immediately. The question now is whether process change holds. Money moving once is not the same as money moving consistently. But consistency is what displacement actually requires.

The visible mobilization of Baylight is entering a new phase. On October tenth, twelve days from the start of this month, foundation piling begins on the stadium site. That date has weight because it shifts the project from equipment staging to actual construction. Workforce deployment is already active — construction crews are hiring, apprenticeships are being filled, the labor pipeline is absorbing the project's first wave of demand. Elena Lewis, a forty-eight-year-old longshoreman at the Port of Oakland, on what she's seeing on the waterfront: "The Baylight teams are recruiting. The Port is handling some of it, but it's not just the Port anymore. They're going into neighborhoods, talking to people who've never done formal construction work before."

The TIF close is October thirty-first. What that means is that two billion one hundred million dollars in municipal borrowing becomes legally binding within three weeks. The workforce question isn't just how many jobs are available — it's whether the city's apprenticeship capacity matches the timeline.

The Fruitvale Transit Hub, meanwhile, is in the benefit design phase. Ninety-four residents voted on design preferences this month. Eighty-seven percent ranked the Community Benefit Maximum scenario in their top two choices. The Community Benefit Maximum means thirty-year rent locks for small businesses, thirty-five percent affordable housing with hundred-year affordability protections via community land trust, and real enforcement

authority on developer compliance. Council votes in November. Jalen Hill, who works the line at a Jack London restaurant: "One project brings money into the neighborhood through construction. One project brings money in through long-term development and jobs. Both need to work together or both break."

CULTURE & COMMUNITY — OAKLAND

Arman Gutiérrez / Bay Tribune

BY MARIA KEEN

The first thing you notice about the Fruitvale corridor on a September morning is the quiet between storms. Summer heat has loosened its grip but hasn't quite released it. The street smells like bakery flour and car exhaust. Someone's radio plays salsa two blocks south.

Lucia Polito stood outside St. Columba Catholic Church with a stack of folded white sheets, waiting for the fellowship hall to open. She's 64, has lived three blocks from this church for longer than she can easily count, and comes every Saturday without fail. But this Saturday felt different.

"We're setting up for people to remember," she said, fitting a key into the lock. "Juneteenth was in June. But some things don't stay in June."

The cycle has turned. September is here. And across Oakland's neighborhoods, small gestures are keeping Juneteenth alive in community spaces weeks after the actual date passed — not as nostalgia, but as something more active. A commitment to keep what that day means from dissolving into the calendar.

St. Columba was hosting a community lunch to mark emancipation and freedom. Nothing fancy. Lucia was preparing the hall. Tables would go here, chairs there. People would come, eat, listen to someone speak about the weight and the grace of the Juneteenth story. Then they'd leave and go back to their weeks.

"I don't think about it much," Lucia said. "I just come. And when things need doing, I help do them."

At the Cathedral of Christ the Light on Grand Avenue, the Saturday food pantry had its own Juneteenth moment this month — a volunteer named DeMarco brought his uncle, who had never been inside the cathedral before, to see what "free food meant around here." One person brought another. The circle expanded. By the time they left, the uncle was shaking hands with people he'd never met, and said something that landed: "If they're doing this now, I wonder what they were doing in June when I wasn't paying attention."

BY ELLIOT GRAYE

Allen Temple Baptist Church on 85th Avenue in East Oakland has been doing quiet work for longer than most people downtown can name. Saturday food pantry. Community clinic space. A fellowship hall that opens in seasons of crisis and stays open in seasons of ordinary need.

This month, the congregation opened its doors wider. Not with fanfare. With intention.

The event spread the way important things spread in East Oakland — word of mouth, household to household, the way people know things who pay attention to what churches do when nobody's watching.

Allen Temple held community support hours. The kind where you don't fill out forms or prove need. You come, you eat, you talk to people who work at the church, you leave knowing there's a place that will open its doors next Saturday too.

"We don't ask what brought you here," the pastor said. Not as marketing language. As fact.

Acts Full Gospel Church in West Oakland did similar work this month — opening fellowship space, creating the conditions where people could sit and exist without transaction. Not charity as the world uses it. Friendship as the church understands it.

BY ANGELA REYES

First Presbyterian Church in Downtown Oakland has always been the kind of place that doesn't announce what it does. No marquee updates about programs. Just the doors open, the coffee brewing, and people arriving because they knew someone who told them where to find help.

The after-school tutoring program that started quietly in August expanded its hours and opened additional slots for students from across the city. Not just downtown kids. Kids whose schools are understaffed, whose families are stretching resources thin, whose neighborhoods have watched educational investment leave in waves.

"We don't brand this," a tutor said. "But we show up."

The program is staffed by volunteers, funded by donations that don't make announcements, and running in the fellowship hall because it's available and it's stable. Stability. A room that stays open. A time slot you can count on. Tutors who arrive and stay.

The volunteers don't frame it that way. They just say: "The kids keep coming. So we keep showing up."

SPORTS — OAKLAND

BY ANTHONY, BAY TRIBUNE SPORTS

The fog had barely lifted off the waterfront when Travis Coles threw his last pitch of the evening — a called third strike at the knees, the fourteenth strikeout of the night, punctuating nine innings of baseball so complete and so quiet that the Coliseum crowd spent the final three frames in the particular kind of hush that fans reserve for something they know they're watching for the first time.

The Oakland A's beat the Los Angeles Angels four to nothing on a one-hitter. Coles threw all nine innings. He allowed no runs, one hit, no walks, and retired the final twelve batters in succession.

Those are not preseason numbers. Those are not numbers from a scheduled showcase. Those are, by any measure the game has invented, the numbers of a starting pitcher operating at the absolute summit of his abilities.

The front office paid forty-six point one eight million dollars over two years to acquire Coles from Washington this past offseason. Skeptics noted the price. They noted the age — twenty-two, never fully tested in a pennant environment. They noted that Washington's pitching infrastructure had a way of inflating staff performances that didn't always survive a zip code change. General Manager Mike Paulson heard every version of this concern and traded for Coles anyway.

Wednesday night at the Coliseum, Coles did not make Paulson look prescient. He made Paulson look like someone who had simply watched the right pitcher throw.

The stuff was not complicated. Coles worked primarily with a four-seam fastball sitting at ninety-six miles per hour and a changeup that arrived twelve miles per hour slower and moved like a man stepping off a curb. His curveball, deployed sparingly and mainly against left-handed hitters, produced five of his fourteen strikeouts. The Angels' lineup had no answer for the combination by the fourth inning. By the seventh, they had stopped looking for one.

Danny Horn provided all the offense the A's needed, depositing a second-inning solo home run into the left-field seats and driving in a second run on a sacrifice fly two innings later. The game was not particularly close after the fifth.

What matters more than the score is the context. The Oakland rotation enters September with five starters and a question that has haunted every dynasty's back half: what happens when the young arm at the bottom of the order grows into the arm at the top? With Esteban Ramos anchoring the one slot and Henry Rivas solid in two, the A's have not had an answer at three that didn't require negotiation. Until now, that negotiation produced results. Coles, on Wednesday, produced a different kind of certainty.

Deacon Seymour, in his first year managing this club, said after the game that he left Coles in to finish the job because the pitch count was reasonable and because, as he put it, removing a pitcher in the middle of something like that would have been an act of administrative cowardice.

That is not how most managers talk. That is how managers talk when they've inherited a culture that values finishing things.

The A's are three and zero. The season is four games old. Neither of these facts should be weighted heavily in any serious projection. But the manner of this particular win — efficient, dominant, unexpectedly complete — points toward something the skeptics hadn't fully priced into their concerns about this rotation.

Coles can do this.

BY P SLAYER, BAY TRIBUNE SPORTS

I was at the Pennant & Pint in Jack London Square on Saturday when Benji Dillon gave up his fourth run of the second inning, and I watched DeShawn Hartley — fifty-nine years old, been sitting at that bar since Clinton was president — set down his beer without taking a sip and just stare at the screen.

"He's tired," DeShawn said.

Not angry. Not alarmed. Just tired. Like he'd watched someone he loved walk a little slower than usual and was beginning to understand what that meant.

Here is what the box score says about Benji Dillon's Saturday afternoon: four innings, nine hits, seven earned runs, one strikeout. Five-time Cy Young winner. Three thousand two hundred and nineteen career strikeouts. Left-hander with a pick-off move that was once studied at the college level. Roughed up by the Cleveland Guardians in a way that made people at bars in Jack London Square go very quiet.

Now. Before I write the sentence that some portion of this readership is waiting for — the sentence about decline and farewells and the cruelty of watching greatness diminish — let me tell you what else happened on Saturday.

Vinnie Keane stepped to the plate in the eighth inning of a game the A's were trailing seven to six. His body has hit four hundred and thirty-six home runs in this league. His body has won this franchise six World Series championships. His body is forty-something and the calendar cannot touch what is in it. He drove a baseball into the seats in right-center field, Oakland took the lead, and they held it.

Three for four. Home run. Two RBI. Go-ahead shot in the eighth.

Then Bryan Franco happened.

I didn't know Bryan Franco's name a year ago. He came over in the Busch trade — the same transaction that brought that video board standing ovation on Saturday when Busch took his first at-bat back in Oakland, tipping his helmet to a crowd that still knows what he meant to this city. Franco went the other direction in that trade. Twenty-three years old. Started the season in the minors. And on Saturday in his first game at this level, he hit two home runs.

Two.

Someone at the bar asked if Franco was for real. I said I had no idea, which is the honest answer, but I also said that hitting two home runs in your first major league game is a fact that exists independent of whether it holds up later.

Now. Here is the counter-argument I should address directly, because I've already seen it online and I'll hear it in person by Tuesday: that what we saw from Dillon is the beginning of the end, that four innings and nine hits and seven runs is a sign we should have seen coming, that a great career has moved past its final worthy chapter. Some fans will say this season was already written and the Guardians just read the last page early.

They're wrong. And not because I refuse to see it — I saw the same screen DeShawn was watching. I know what an aging starter's command looks like when it's not there. I know what a flat fastball sounds like coming off a bat nine times in four innings.

But here is what I also know: this team won the game. It won because it absorbed a bad start from a legend and still found a way, because its forty-something DH is still capable of a moment in the eighth that shuts down every conversation except the one about how he went yard when it counted, because a kid in his first day on the job hit the ball into the seats twice like he'd been doing it for years.

This team has always been about what happens after the difficult thing. Dillon is going to have more bad days this season. So is every pitcher who has been throwing competitive major league baseball for the better part of two decades. The question was never whether it would happen. The question is what comes after.

What came after on Saturday was an 8-7 win, a 4-1 record, and Bryan Franco looking at his second home run trot like he was trying to memorize the feeling.

I want to watch this team all September.

DeShawn finished his beer. He didn't say anything else.

He didn't need to.

BY HAL RICHMOND, BAY TRIBUNE SPORTS

There is a man named Mason Miller who used to play for this franchise and who now lives in Downtown Oakland in a two-room apartment above a Vietnamese restaurant on Webster Street and who attends every home game he can get to, taking the BART from 12th Street station the way he has for as long as he has lived here. He spent four years in the A's system in the late twenties, never made the opening day roster, retired at twenty-seven with a .241 batting average in Triple-A and no regrets that he has ever shared with me. We have coffee sometimes when the season opens.

I asked him last week what he remembered most about the early weeks of a season, when a player's numbers look like nothing and the calendar has barely turned.

He thought about it for a moment. Then he said: "That the first two weeks are not the season. They're practice for believing you're in the season."

I have been writing about baseball for a long time. That is the most useful sentence I have heard anyone say about early September statistics in years.

The Oakland A's are four and one. Three of their most closely watched hitters — Darrin Davis, Ernesto Quintero, and Eric Tavares — are batting a combined aggregate that would alarm any statistician and

dismay any fan who did not understand the nature of what the first weeks of a baseball season actually measure.

Davis, who won the Most Valuable Player award last season before the injury took him, is hitting fifty-nine thousandths of a point on the batting average scale. He drove in two runs in his first games back. He has not hit a home run. He is also recovering from an anterior cruciate ligament repair — a procedure that the body requires approximately twelve to fourteen months to process fully, regardless of how the physical therapist's report is worded.

Quintero is twenty-four years old and batting fifty points on average with no extra-base hits. He is also making loud contact when he makes contact. The ball comes off his bat with a sound that belongs to a different set of outcomes than the ones he's producing.

Tavares arrived with a contract worth two hundred and twenty-five million dollars and the weight that number places on a player's first two weeks of production is not a baseball variable. It is a psychological one. He is hitting one hundred seventy-six thousandths. He has one home run and two runs batted in.

I have a rule I apply to every early-season numbers conversation: I do not write a player off until the heat comes. September in Oakland is a transitional month — the bay fog still covers the morning, the afternoon warms to something manageable, and the games are played in that particular Northern California light that reveals rather than obscures. By the time the fog lifts for good, these numbers will mean something different.

Mason Miller reminded me of that over coffee. He taught junior high school science in Fruitvale for twelve years after he stopped playing — the kind of teacher who told his students that an experiment failing its first run does not mean the hypothesis is wrong, it means you are still collecting data.

The A's are collecting data. The players who matter in this city's October story are somewhere inside the players producing these early numbers, and the calendar will find them.

It always does.

SKYLINE TRIBUNE — CHICAGO BUREAU

SKYLINE TRIBUNE — CHICAGO BUREAU

BY SELENA GRANT, BAY TRIBUNE CHICAGO BUREAU

The Bulls won Game 7 against Cleveland at the United Center on a Friday night, and the correct response to that is not to talk about what it means for the city. The correct response is to talk about what it means for the roster.

Let's start with what a Game 7 win actually requires. You need your best player to be your best player in a game where every possession is contested and the margin for error is close to zero. Josh Giddey, who put up 39 points in Game 5 against Orlando to reverse a 0-2 series deficit, came through the Cleveland series as the player this roster needed him to become. The Bulls got there through six games of meaningful Giddey-led possessions, and they finished it. That is not an accident. That is a point guard who has figured something out about playoff basketball that he did not know in October.

Hank Trepagnier's Rookie of the Year case, which entered the postseason as a statistical argument — 16.7 points, 8.2 rebounds, 5.1 assists, 1.3 steals, 1.5 blocks per game in the regular season, plus the Cup MVP — is now a playoff argument. A nineteen-year-old averaging those numbers through the regular season is impressive. A nineteen-year-old carrying meaningful minutes through back-to-back playoff series is something different.

Then there is Adash Stanley.

The Stanley technical foul situation is not "he's too physical." The story is structural. Paulson built this roster as a counter to the finesse-heavy teams at the top of the East — Stanley's edge is not a side effect of the design, it is the design. When Stanley sets a screen that leaves an opponent reconsidering their path to the basket, that is information. When Stanley gets a technical for talking after a contested play, that is also information, but of a different kind.

The problem in a playoff series is that the referees adjust. Stanley picked up multiple technicals through the Cleveland series. In the conference semifinals, a well-timed Stanley technical in a tight fourth quarter is a free point and a free possession for the opponent. Whether Stanley has internalized the adjustment is the question the next round will answer.

A source familiar with the front office's thinking said this week that Paulson's preparation for the semifinals has been "entirely basketball." His contract status, the ownership statement from March, the parallel timeline in Golden State — none of it has surfaced in the way the team approaches these games. That may be the clearest thing Paulson has communicated all season, even without saying a word.

The Bulls are in the conference semifinals. That is real. So is everything else.

BY TALIA FINCH, BAY TRIBUNE CHICAGO BUREAU

The tamale truck parks at the corner of 35th and Halsted on Fridays between eleven and two, and on this particular Friday the line stretched back toward the school.

Paulette Okafor was already holding hers when I found her — corn husk, the green chile one, eating it standing up in the way you do when you're on a thirty-minute lunch and the weather has finally decided to be something other than August. She had her jacket on for the first time since May.

"Don't ask me how long I waited," she said. "Worth it."

I asked if she'd watched the game.

"I watched it with my jacket on and my hands on the table," she said. "I didn't move. I was afraid to move."

The Bulls had won Game 7 against Cleveland the night before. Paulette had watched it in her living room, same as she'd watched every game in this run — curtains open, the room getting darker as the game went on, not getting up to turn on the lights because that would mean leaving the couch, and leaving the couch would mean something happened that required standing up. She didn't stand up. Not until it was over.

"I think I was holding my breath from the third quarter," she said. "I came back to work this morning and my neck hurt."

The tamale truck belongs to a man named Darius Reeves, forty-four, who has been parking at this corner since 2038. He told me he'd watched the game too, from the TV over the prep station in the truck's commissary kitchen.

"They come in different," he said, wrapping an order without looking up. "When they win a big one, they don't stand in line the same way. Everybody's talking. Everybody's got something they need to say out loud."

He'd sold out of the corn husk green chile by 11:40.

Raymond Polk came around twelve-fifteen, too late for the tamales. He got the elotes instead and stood on the sidewalk across from Paulette and ate it out of a paper cup.

"I did not feel only the good thing this time," he said.

Paulette looked at him.

"I felt the good thing a lot," he said. "Like, most of it. But there was still — you know." He tipped his head slightly, the way he does when he's pointing at something he'd rather not name directly.

"The other thing," Paulette said.

"The other thing."

Bridgeport has been carrying the other thing since March — the ownership statement, the unresolved contract, the question that travels alongside every win like a bag nobody agreed to check. A Game 7 win doesn't dissolve it. The Bulls are in the conference semifinals for the first time under Paulson. The neighborhood gets to feel that. It's just that the neighborhood has gotten good at feeling two things at once.

"You know what she said to me last time?" Raymond asked, nodding at Paulette. "She said she wanted to watch basketball like a person who just watches basketball."

"I remember," Paulette said.

"Did you?"

She thought about it. She took the last bite of the tamale and folded the corn husk back on itself the way you do when you're not ready to throw it away yet.

"I watched it like a person who just watches basketball," she said, "and then I went to bed and laid there for two hours thinking about the other thing."

Raymond laughed. It was a real laugh, which is different from the ones he gives when something is just ironic.

"That's about right," he said.

Darius Reeves pulled the service window closed at two o'clock exactly. The line had cleared twenty minutes earlier. He'd be back next Friday. If the Bulls were still alive — and they were, they were in the conference semifinals — there would be a line.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Check That Hasn't Arrived To the Editor: I read that fifty-three families have been approved for Stabilization Fund disbursements. Twelve have received money. The rest of us are still waiting. I applied eight months ago. I was approved four months ago. I have called OEWD's office six times. Each time I am told my application is in processing. Each time the person on the phone sounds like they are reading from the same piece of paper. My landlord is not waiting. My landlord raised rent in July. The $18,000 I was approved for would have covered the difference for two years. Instead I am looking at moving to Hayward in November because the city that approved me for help cannot figure out how to write a check. I am glad the Mayor issued a directive. I hope it works. But a directive is not a check.

— Irene Fay, 61, West Oakland

What Fruitvale Actually Said To the Editor: I was one of the ninety-four people who showed up to vote on the Transit Hub design. I brought my mother. She brought her neighbor. We stood in a room with ballots and voted for the strongest community protections because we have lived here long enough to know what happens when you don't. People who don't live in Fruitvale keep telling us what we should want. We voted. Fifty-two percent first choice. Eighty-seven percent top two. The numbers are not ambiguous. What I want now is simple: a community benefit agreement that is legally binding, not advisory. My family has been in this neighborhood for twenty-three years. We are not asking to be consulted. We are asking to be protected.

— Marisol Trujillo, 44, Fruitvale

Day 34 To the Editor: My son had a mental health crisis in April. We called 911. Two patrol officers showed up. They were professional and they were kind. They were also not trained for what was happening in my living room. OARI is eleven days from launching. Twelve responders hired. Dispatch being tested. I don't care about the politics — who voted yes, who voted no, who is still watching. I care that the next family who calls 911 at two in the morning gets someone who knows what a panic attack looks like. Eleven days. Please finish this.

— Dennis Okafor, 52, East Oakland

The Piles Go In To the Editor: I have been a longshoreman at the Port for nineteen years. I watched Howard Terminal go from a shipping facility to an argument to a rendering to a construction site. October tenth is the day the piles go in. I don't need the Mayor to tell me what that means. I can see the equipment from the dock. What I want to say to the people who fought this for years: it's happening. You can argue about the TIF or the bond or the developer margins. The piles are going in. The jobs are real. My nephew starts his apprenticeship next month. Some things stop being an argument and start being a building. This is that.

— Curtis Webb, 47, West Oakland

September Morning To the Editor: This is not about policy. I walk my dog along Lake Merritt every morning at six. The light this time of year comes in low across the water and hits the buildings on the east side before it reaches the lake itself. There is a man who rows a single scull every morning at the same time. We have never spoken. We nod. The city does important things. It passes initiatives and builds transit hubs and argues about budgets. But the thing that makes me stay is the six o'clock light and the man in the scull and the fact that my dog knows the route better than I do. Oakland is a good city. I wanted to say that because nobody writes letters to say things are fine.

— Grace Yamamoto, 68, Adams Point

QUICK TAKES - A's homestand continues through end of September. Coles starts again Thursday. - Youth Apprenticeship Pipeline application window opens next week — first cohort targets Baylight-adjacent construction trades. - Port of Oakland Green Modernization federal grant application still in federal pipeline. No update from Washington. - First Friday returns October 3. Telegraph Avenue closures begin at 5 PM.

COMING NEXT - OARI Day 45: Does the program launch? Does Montez sign? - Stabilization Fund: Did the checks actually go out? - Baylight: Foundation piles in the ground. What does the construction site look like? - Fruitvale Transit Hub: CBA language begins to take shape before C91 vote. - A's September stretch: Davis, Quintero, Tavares — do the bats wake up?

ARTICLE TABLE

CITIZEN USAGE LOG Civic: Beverly Hayes (POP-00772), Avery Santana (POP-00034), Denise Carter (POP-00501), Rose Delgado (POP-00503), Janae Rivers (POP-00043), Leonard Tran (POP-00502), Ramon Vega (POP-00042), Warren Ashford, Nina Chen, Elliott Crane, Keisha Ramos, Marcus Webb, Brenda Okoro, Elena Soria Dominguez Business: Elena Lewis (POP-00193), Jalen Hill (POP-00089), Beverly Hayes Sports: Travis Coles, Danny Horn, Benji Dillon, Vinnie Keane, Bryan Franco, Darrin Davis, Ernesto Quintero, Eric Tavares, Esteban Ramos, Henry Rivas, Deacon Seymour, DeShawn Hartley (POP-00015), Mason Miller (POP-00127) Culture: Lucia Polito (POP-00004), DeMarco (new), DeMarco's Uncle (new) Chicago: Josh Giddey, Hank Trepagnier, Adash Stanley, Mike Paulson, Paulette Okafor, Raymond Polk, Darius Reeves (new) Letters: Irene Fay (POP-00188), Marisol Trujillo (POP-00267), Dennis Okafor (POP-00391), Curtis Webb (POP-00211), Grace Yamamoto (POP-00156)

CONTINUITY NOTES - Stabilization Fund: Authorization bottleneck broken. 53 approved, disbursements within 10 days. 277 in rolling two-week review. Track delivery in C90. - OARI: Day 34 of 45. 12 of 18 hired. Dispatch in testing. MOU unsigned. Day 45 is the story next cycle. - Transit Hub: Community mandate clear (87% top-two). CBA being drafted. C91 vote. - Baylight: Phase 1 mobilization complete. Foundation piling Oct 10. TIF close Dec 31. - Health Center: Design 85%. HCAI application August 2026. GC RFP ready C90. - Osei: Still absent. Cortez covering. - A's: 4-1. Coles dominant. Dillon rough. Keane heroic. Franco arrived. Davis/Quintero/Tavares cold. - Bulls: Eastern Conference semifinals. Giddey emerging. Stanley technicals a live risk. Paulson silent. - Paulette/Raymond: Feeling two things at once. The other thing is still there.

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